



Date: February 27th, 2026

To: Chairman Michael Summers, State Board of Elections

CC'ed: Maryland State Board of Elections; Jared DeMarinis, Maryland State Elections Administrator

From: Nikki Tyree, Executive Director, League of Women Voters of Maryland, and Linda T. Kohn, President, League of Women Voters of Maryland

Subject: Recent Remarks at February 19th Board Meeting

At the recent February 19th Maryland State Board of Elections meeting, a guest speaker was able to attend and make public comments. These comments included three broad areas that she and her organization wanted addressed:

1. List Maintenance. This came with the assertion that Marylanders who hadn't voted in two election cycles were still listed as active and that inactive members were being willfully included on Maryland's voter rolls.
2. Provisional Voting. There was an ask that provisional voters be assigned a code (an initiative being undertaken by the SBE staff) and that these codes be made public.
3. Underage registrants were being misled by their voter cards. There was a claim that 471 youth voters voted illegally.

We applaud the State Board's willingness to make time for public comments from Marylanders; everybody has the opportunity to attend and offer their views. However, two serious problems occurred. First, after the speaker finished making her remarks, she was met with such rhetoric as "thank you for those insights... and creating a record" and "your effort to secure the vote." The tone and manner in which this was delivered made it sound to the audience as if the State Board not only approved of her messaging but also that her remarks carried authority. We are not commenting on thanking the speaker for attending; rather, we are drawing attention to the fact that, to us and therefore likely to the average listener, it sounded as if the Board was validating the speaker.

Second, and perhaps even more serious, is that after she was done speaking, there was no rebuttal. Neither the Board nor the State Administrator attempted to respond to her and instead allowed her comments to hang unchallenged, without facts or even being questioned until the facts are determined, to a streaming audience and anyone who has watched it since then. To be clear: Maryland's votes are secure, and that is entirely what the Board works for. That is the answer that should have been given during the meeting.



As you can imagine, this is disturbing to the League. We find ourselves in a political climate that is being overburdened with mis- and disinformation. In this instance, disinformation was shared. For example, the idea that the Maryland voter rolls are hosting almost 1 million people illegally is, on the face of it, just ludicrous. The same goes for asserting that Marylanders under 18 are somehow able to fully access the ballot box and that their votes are being cast and counted. It is a well-known fact that some local jurisdictions permit 16-year-olds to register and vote only in local elections. Again, we would never ask that the public be prevented from speaking, but problems arise when Maryland's State Board of Elections does nothing to stop the spread of this false narrative. Even going so far as to have a private response to the speaker. It's great to respond to disinformation, but only if everyone can access it.

The speaker was commenting on behalf of a group called Secure the Vote Maryland. This is an organization, established in almost every state, that is dedicated to spreading disinformation about our elections. Such claims range from Maryland's drop boxes are unsafe to the only way to have truly accurate elections is to return to 100% in-person paper ballots. Obviously, as the League, we are troubled by these assertions.

The League has a long history of working closely with the Maryland State Board of Elections and views the agency as a partner in furthering voter participation in Democracy. However, we are disappointed that truth was not the bedrock of February's Board meeting. Therefore, we request the following actions be taken:

1. Any and all correspondence written by the State Board and/or the State Administrator of Elections should be made publicly available and easily accessible.
2. This response is be shared at the March Board of Elections meeting, as well as sharing that this response is available online.
3. An acknowledgement by the State Board of Elections Chairman that, regardless of public comments, the Board knows that Maryland elections are secure.

The League thanks you in advance for your attention to this and for consideration of the above request. It will take real partnership and understanding to defeat disinformation in the coming months. We are excited to continue our partnership with the State Board of Elections as we move forward into the midterm elections and bring as many Maryland voters to the ballot box as possible.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "N. Tyree".

Nikki Tyree, Executive Director

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Linda T. Kohn".

Linda T. Kohn, President

League of Women Voters of Maryland